



Agent 001

FEELING BLUE

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Ever since its introduction into the Indian markets via mobile phones, PMPs, PDAs, speakers and also printers, Bluetooth, as a technology, has always been something that is perceived as being actively sought after and desired. Very few people actually know the advantages of Bluetooth as a wireless protocol for data transmission, but suddenly everybody started demanding Bluetooth on their mobiles. Due to its one-to-one nature and inbuilt security features, Bluetooth sees a lot of usage in wireless hands-free units used with mobile phones and wireless data transfers between two devices. Currently, A2DP (Advanced Audio Distribution Profile) is a special protocol built into the Bluetooth standard that allows for streaming of high-quality stereo audio from one A2DP supporting device, such as a phone or PMP, to another device such as a Bluetooth headset or a speaker set.

First, Bluetooth is a big plus for consumers. Being wireless, it puts an end to cable clutter. Bluetooth headphones are becoming quite popular and if your music device is a phone or PMP that is Bluetooth capable with A2DP, then you should definitely consider a pair. Sound quality is as good as a wired headset. Obviously, it has a certain working range and of course the clearer the line of sight between the receiver and the transmitter the better the sound quality will be. Bluetooth speakers are also becoming common, although not as common as headsets. The most common accessory, however, remains the wireless hands-free unit that is a boon to virtually anyone who uses a cellular phone.

When looking at Bluetooth hands-free kits, the biggest players in terms of the volume of their sales are the cellular handset manufacturers themselves. The problem is that there are very few options available from these manufacturers and these models only work with handsets from the same manufacturer. Third-party hands-free unit suppliers are limited to Jabra and Plantronics. Jabra has a wide range of hands-free Bluetooth units available. The cheapest is the Jabra BT-2010. It's priced at Rs. 1,600 or so and is built simply but well, and is a mono-hands-free Bluetooth unit. The Jabra BT-125 is the next model I came across. Priced at Rs. 1,800, it's a little sleeker than the BT-2010, but otherwise offers the same functionality. The Jabra BT5020 is one of the sleeker and more feature-rich headsets around. It does not have a detachable armature (the part that secures the Bluetooth device on your ear). Instead, the entire device is built in a curve with the earpiece on one end and the microphone on the other. This makes it look very sleek. Since the entire thing wraps around your ear, sans protrusions, this is one of the few sets that you can wear even with a helmet on: Although not too comfortable, at least it's possible. Other headsets that have an earpiece sticking in your ear with the mouthpiece protruding out cannot be worn with a helmet. The BT5020 supports up to two profiles and can thus be paired with two Bluetooth-capable handsets, which is a great plus for those with two phones. Additionally, it has wind-noise reduction; that is a sound-filtering system that, although basic, works well. Priced at Rs. 3,850, this headset is a



good deal — a pity stereo isn't supported.

The BT8040 was the only other headset that caught my attention because of its features. Priced at Rs. 6,100, this is the ultimate mate for those with multiple phones or other BT devices. Up to eight devices can be paired and two devices can be paired at the same time — an unbeatable plus for those who carry two phones around. Additionally, it can be paired with other Bluetooth devices and even a PC with Bluetooth to stream music. Intelligent volume control is built-in; this boosts volume for a lower volume voice and decreases the volume in case there is background noise. The Jabra JX-10 is also available for Rs. 5,500. However, it doesn't have any special features — it's just superbly designed and really looks like it stepped off a ramp.

One of the more interesting offerings from Jabra is the BT-3030. Priced at Rs. 3,200, the BT-3030 looks like a dog tag. The best part is that this unit does not have headphones, which means that you can use your own stereo earphones provided they have a 3.5-mm pin. This device can be used with a phone as a hands-free device or with any device for music — the biggest advantage here being the option for stereo sound. It even has buttons for next/previous track functions.

Plantronics' Voyager 510 is another unit that supports pairing with two devices and has a smart switch feature that recognises which device is currently being used and automatically switches to that device's profile. It's priced at Rs. 4,100 and we feel that this is a decent price, considering Jabra's BT5020 doesn't switch automatically between two paired devices. Plantronics' Voyager 855 is also available for Rs. 6,790 and this unit cleverly incorporates a detachable additional earpiece, which when plugged in makes the Voyager 855 a pure stereo device. When using it for calls, you can simply unplug this additional cable and use it as a mono wireless headset. While the music quality of this device is also pretty good, it's a little overpriced. The Pulsar 590E is a Bluetooth headset that has a built in microphone for use with phones. This headset is not really portable, but suitable for those looking for wireless headphones — the earcups themselves are supra-aural. Logitech's Free Pulse Bluetooth headphones are also available. These are for people who only want a set of wireless headphones for music without a microphone. Sound quality is good, definitely good enough for music although audiophile-grade listeners will look for better sonic performance. However, priced at Rs. 7,100, these headphones sound good and are very comfortable. Dell also has an option for Bluetooth headphones — the BH200 I saw at one vendor. Although these were not meant for sale and bundled with their XPS M1530 notebook, yet they are pretty neat and offer decent sound with a good microphone. Priced at Rs. 4,000, this is a cheaper option for those looking at something more affordable — the minus is the restricted availability.

When it comes to Bluetooth speakers, I could not find many options in the market. In fact, the only speaker setup that was available with two of the vendors was the Logitech Pure-Fi Mobile, which is a Bluetooth speaker system. This system is claimed to give as much as 12 hours of music playback between recharges. Priced at Rs. 10,000, these speakers consist of two pressure and two active 2-inch drivers and can be charged via the mains or USB.

Of the available options, I found the Jabra BT-3030 the most attractive for someone looking at a stereo Bluetooth headset for music, mainly because of the flexibility of using your own cans with them. For users looking for a wireless mate to their phones, the BT5020 is a good offering that offers the best of features at a decent price. ■

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